

KF Reading Guide for HPKPⁱ

Chapters 7 & 8: *Purity and Pollution*

Chapter Seven: Purity and Pollution

1. What is perhaps our greatest loss if we cannot understand the purity system of the early church? (241.1)

2. For what two reasons do the people of our century find it difficult to comprehend purity and pollution and the distinctions between the pure and defiled? (241.1–242.2)
 - A.

 - B.

3. In your opinion, what was the purpose of “dressing up” for church? (242.2)

4. What was vitally meaningful to the writers of the New Testament? (242.3)

5. Why were the concepts of purity and pollution still essential for the people God was calling out? (242.3–243.1)

6. How does Dr. deSilva define the following words? (243.2)
 - A. Purity:

 - B. Pollution:

7. What do you think our society perceives as purity or pollution? What do you consider to be pure or polluted?

Defining Holiness, Purity, and Pollution

8. What must be in place before something can even be considered “dirt?” (246.2)

9. With what is purity fundamentally concerned? (246.2)

10. What does purity tell us and enable us to know? (246.2)

11. How does de Silva define “holy”? (247.1)

12. What does “defilement” mean? (248.2)

13. What is not right for God or for good people? (248, footnote 12)

14. What four things does purity do for a group? (249.1)

- A.
- B.
- C.
- D.

Purity and Pollution in the Greco-Roman World

15. What does the threat of pollution encourage? (249, footnote 14)

16. What did the concepts “holy”, “pure” and “defiled” do for the early Christian community? (253.2)

Purity and Pollution in the Jewish World

17. Define the following terms: (253.2–254.1)

A. Common (or profane):

B. Holy:

C. Clean:

D. Unclean:

18. What pollutions would cause the land to vomit forth its inhabitants? (255.1)

19. What did confronting the holy with the unclean generate? (255.3)

The Purity Maps of Torah and Early Judaism

Maps of people

20. Which aspects of these maps of people interest you? (256.4–258.2)

Maps of spaces

21. What stood at the center of the Jewish map of the world? (258.3)

22. In the temple, what two spheres intersected? (258.3)

Maps of time

23. What was a marker of the social identity of the Jewish people? (259.4)

24. Why was the Sabbath truly distinctive? (260.1)

25. Keeping the Sabbath is also an essential element of what? (260.1)

Dietary Regulations

26. Jewish cuisine becomes an essential point at which what lines are drawn? (261.4–262.1)

Maps of the body

27. Concerns over what entered and exited the body correlated with what? (262.2)

Negotiating with the holy and coping with pollution through ritual

28. Describe the three phases involved in the ritual process. (265.2)

A.

B.

C.

29. What is the liminal period a time for? (266.1)

30. What do the holy places mirror? (266.3)

“Ethical” holiness and pollution

31. The pious Jew observed no distinction between what? (267.2–268.1)

32. What kinds of behavior were severely sanctioned against? What was the remedy? (268.2)

The Meaningfulness of Purity Regulations and Pollution Taboos in Judaism

33. What is the central rationale for observing purity regulations? (269.3)

34. What is the ultimate reason for observing distinctions between clean and unclean and holy and common? (270.2)

35. What growth results from obedience to Torah according to 4 Maccabees? (273.2)

36. The daily regulations concerning body purity may well function as what? (274.1)

Concern for Purity in Early Judaism

37. The observant Jew was interested in maintaining purity in what two areas? (277.2)

38. What did God desire the Jews to reflect? (277.2)

Chapter Eight: Purity and the New Testament

1. In the light of the potential blessings and dangers, what great care must be taken by those who live in God's presence? (279.1)

2. What did clean and pure reflect? (279.1)

Rewriting Israel's purity maps

3. What gave Jesus the authority to redefine the sacred purity regulations of Judaism? (280.1)

4. What two broad principles for applying Jewish purity regulations guided early Christians in applying Torah ordinances? (280.2)

A.

B.

5. In what two ways were the concepts of purity a significant aspect of Christian ideology? (281.2)

A.

B.

Pure and defiling foods

6. What is the only observance of clean and unclean that God requires? (282.4)

7. If "nothing is unclean in itself" (Romans 14:14), what makes it unclean? (283.1)

8. How did the few strategic pollution taboos support the Christian community? (283.1)

9. Can you think of pollution taboos today that are often imposed on Christians?

Rewriting maps of holy and defiling people

10. What was Jesus consistently willing to do? (283.3)

11. What do the Gospels present Jesus as encountering? (284.3)

12. What was a critical extension of the principle of God's holiness in Jesus's cleansing and sanctifying the unclean? (285.2)

13. What does it mean to be "justified"? (288.2)

Purity and time

14. What two points did Jesus debate concerning what profanes or sanctifies the Sabbath? (289.2–290.2)

A.

B.

15. By healing on the Sabbath, what does Jesus claim? (290.3)

Reconfiguring sacred space

16. For Christians, what sacred space replaced the Jerusalem temple? (291.2)

17. According to Paul, what else is sacred space? (293.2)

18. What becomes an important impetus to ethical behavior? (293.3)

Purity, pollution, and ethics

19. What do holiness and purity still require? (294.5)

20. Why are prostitution and fornication singularly inappropriate? (294.6)

21. What three classes of sin censured as defiling in the New Testament correspond closely with sources of defilement in Leviticus? (296.2)
 - A.
 - B.
 - C.

22. What other pollutions did Paul and Jesus identify? (296.2)

23. Ethically and culturally speaking, what is holiness? (297.2)

24. What do words like *righteousness* capture? (297.2)

Holiness, pollution, and group boundaries

25. What is safeguarded when individual Christians attend to keeping the boundaries of physical purity intact and impermeable? (297.3–298.1)

26. What does the term “saints” reflect? (299.2)

27. What does James undergird by using purity and pollution language? (300.4)

28. What is Jude’s carefully nuanced way of seeking to restore members who become defiled? (301.3)

Rituals: Boundary Crossing in the Early Church

29. From which sphere, and to which sphere, were those wishing to join the church able to pass? (304.3)

Baptism

30. What were you taught about baptism?

31. What ritual did baptism replace for the Jew? (305.1)

32. Water baptism:

A. What sort of rite is entering the water? (305.3)

B. What does plunging into the water symbolically enact? (305.5)

C. To what rite does rising from the water correspond? (305.5)

D. To what does baptism leaves the Christian marginal? (306.3)

33. What matters more than the way a believer has experienced baptism? (306.3)

Jesus' death as sacrificial act within a ritual process

34. How is the crucifixion, ascension, and exaltation interpreted by the author of Hebrews? (308.1)

35. For what purpose has God devised this great ritual process in which Christians are presently engaged? (310.2)

36. What are Christians called to do in gratitude for Jesus's own journey outside the camp on their behalf? (310.3)

37. What kind of community can we find within this liminal state? (311.2)

Conclusion

38. What purity lines do you look for in the community that you build around you?

39. What does one set of clearly defined lines do for believers? (313.4)

40. What does a second prominent line urge us to do? (314.2)

41. What temptation are we challenged to resist? (314.3)

Conclusion

1. Which of the author's conclusions would you like to discuss or bear in mind? (317–319)

ⁱ This reading guide refers to the 2000 edition of *Honor, Patronage, Kinship & Purity* by David A. deSilva, published by Inter Varsity Press, Downers Grove, IL.